

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Undergraduate Examinations 2018

CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: **THREE** hours

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B** and **ONE** from **EITHER** Section.

The paper consists of **17** questions in total.

All questions are of equal weight.

Candidates are permitted to bring into the examination room, and consult, hardcopy English Language dictionaries. Subject dictionaries are not allowed.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator. Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room. Do not open the question paper until told to do so. All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided. All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided. A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked. At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B** and **ONE** from **EITHER** Section.

SECTION A

1. Is sociology a science?
2. Outline and assess the Neo-Kantian approach which argues that interpretation is key to establishing sociological knowledge.
3. Critically examine Popper's notion of "falsifiability". How relevant are his arguments for sociological research today?
4. Do postmodernist theories succeed in arguing that there is no such thing as reality? What are the implications of such arguments for sociology?
5. Why did Roland Barthes think it so important to analyse the signs and significations of popular culture? How relevant is his argument for understanding society today?
6. Outline and assess Bourdieu's propositions that cultural factors are as important as economic ones in explaining social inequality. How convincing do you find his theory?
7. Using the work of at least two writers, critically examine how sociology can contribute to the understanding of contemporary global inequality.
8. Can feminism explain the experiences of all women? Or should we talk of "feminisms"?
9. What do feminists mean by the concept of "standpoint epistemology"? How convincing do you find their arguments?

END OF SECTION A

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B** and **ONE** from **EITHER** Section.

SECTION B

10. Foucault argued that sociologists need to understand that power is “productive”. What does he mean by this? How convincing do you find his arguments?
11. “One ever feels his [sic] twoness” (Du Bois). Critically examine Du Bois’ analysis of the experience of “race”.
12. “One main task of post-colonial theory is to challenge the distinction between the ‘West and the Rest’.” Using the work of at least two writers, outline and assess this statement.
13. Using the work of at least two writers, critically examine the relations between ‘vision’ and ‘power’.
14. Sociology has tried to challenge biological accounts of sexual difference. How successful has it been in this?
15. Why have some feminists argued that there is a need to go beyond the analysis of the symbolism of the body toward a conceptualization of the material body? How convincing do you find their arguments?
16. Actor-Network-Theory maintains that sociology has spent too long focussing on human actors. Instead, theorists such as Latour argue that there is a need to treat objects as actors. How convincing do you find such arguments?
17. Is it the role of social theory to provide answers or to offer alternative ways of thinking (or seeing) the world?

END OF SECTION B

END OF PAPER